CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

REAL ESTATE AGENT IN THE AI ERA

The median agent with under two years in earns $8,100. That's not a typo — that's NAR's own member data.

★ TL;DR — NO — on entry economics, not AI. BLS puts the sales-agent median at $52,830 (May 2025); the $75K on the old card was the BROKER median, a seat a beginner legally can't hold. And even $53K flatters the start: NAR's 2025 Member Profile puts the median gross for agents with □2 years at $8,100, with 62% under $10,000 and a median of 2 transaction sides. Entry is commission-only self-employment under a broker. The roadmap below is the way OUT: the buildings are fine — sit on the salaried side of them. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$53K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

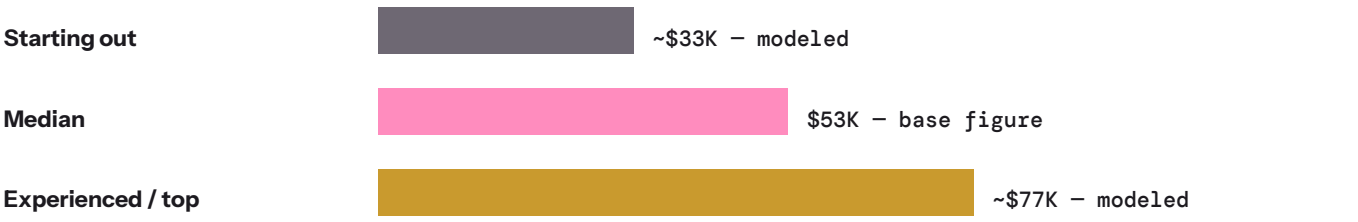
- Fails as a start because: there is no hire and no salary. 92% of agents with □2 years are independent contractors, and the verified beginner median gross is $8,100 a year (NAR).

- The split problem: the $52,830 median mixes in veterans with referral machines; brokers — who take a cut of your split — median $73,220, and you can't be one until you've been an agent for ~2+ years.

- Still worth money: local market knowledge and client trust. Property managers and sales reps get paid salaries for the same two assets — the buildings didn't stop needing humans; the agent pay structure did.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Real Estate Agent is a ~$53K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A REAL ESTATE AGENT ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Prospect constantly: sphere of influence, open houses, referrals
- ✓ Price homes, prepare listings and market them
- ✓ Show properties and read clients' real reactions
- ✓ Negotiate offers and manage contracts to closing

Think: opening a tiny business where you're sales, marketing and product — and the shop pays you only in the months something sells.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI writes listing copy, drafts follow-ups from your notes and answers leads in minutes (Zillow's Follow Up Boss AI) — it raises the response-time bar you compete against. Notice what's missing: BLS's outlook for this occupation names no AI driver at all; the stated constraints are credit, prices and cycles.	Showing homes in person, pricing a weird house, mediating a negotiation — the core duties stay human. That's exactly why this NO is about pay structure, not robots: the work survives, the beginner's economics don't.

⚠ **The folklore '87% of agents fail in five years' has no verifiable source — ignore it. The verified numbers are worse anyway: a median of 2 transaction sides in the 12-year group, splits starting near 50/50, and weeks or months between checks while your bills arrive monthly.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Genuinely your own business, hours and ceiling ✓ Work out in the world, not at a desk ✓ Local expertise compounds — every year in one market makes you sharper	✗ Income in lumps, months apart — possibly $8,100 of it in year one ✗ Evenings and weekends are prime showing time ✗ You are the marketing department, forever, at your own expense

Good fit? You already have a local network, a financial runway of 6+ months, and treat this as starting a business — not taking a job.

Bad fit? You need the licence to turn into income this quarter, or you're counting on the median showing up in year one.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Property Manager	DOOR B — PIVOT TO B2B Sales Rep
BLS median $69,990, growth +4%, ~36,900 openings a year — the salaried side of the same buildings. Managers market vacancies, screen tenants, sign leases and run properties for owners: your showing-and-people skills on a paycheck, with fees that recur monthly instead of closing yearly. Most states route the licence through the real-estate broker licence you may already be studying for, so the coursework isn't wasted. First move: apply to assistant or leasing roles at management firms — that's the paid on-ramp.	A ~$76K median (BLS, Wholesale and Manufacturing Sales Representatives) and ~123,400 openings a year. Agent skills are sales skills: prospecting, sphere-building, objection handling, negotiation under emotional pressure. The difference is the structure — base salary plus commission, a product that reorders monthly, and a pipeline that doesn't reset to zero at every closing. First move: record a 3-minute pitch for a product you believe in; it's the audition tape every sales manager actually watches.

Smart move: If you stay anywhere near property, sell the recurring side: doors under management pay every month. Listings pay when the market feels like it.
Where you land after: You land on the side of real estate with a payroll: managing doors for owners, or carrying a quota where the commission rides on top of a base instead of replacing one.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
DO THE	COUNT YOUR	PICK YOUR	CONVERT THE	APPLY FOR	KEEP THE

STEP 1 — Do the NAR math

FREE · TODAY

- Read NAR's beginner figures yourself: $8,100 median gross at □2 years, 62% under $10K
- Decide with the real distribution in front of you — not the median on a course ad

STEP 2 — Count your runway

WEEK 1

- Price 6 months of your life with near-zero commission income
- If the runway isn't there, the agent seat isn't either — that's arithmetic, not attitude

STEP 3 — Pick your door

WEEK 2

- Door A keeps the buildings: property management, salaried, licence-adjacent
- Door B keeps the selling: B2B reps, base plus commission

STEP 4 — Convert the coursework — WEEKS 2-6

- Pre-licensing hours still count toward the broker-licence routes property management uses
- Add the management stack: leases, fair housing, deposits, notices

STEP 5 — Apply for the paid seat — WEEKS 4-10

- Management firms hire assistants and leasing agents continuously
- Sales employers hire reps who can show prospecting discipline — bring your sphere plan

STEP 6 — Keep the agent option priced honestly — ONGOING

- The licence stays available if you later bring a network and a runway
- Entering with both is a business launch; entering with neither is a lottery ticket

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: read NAR's □2-year numbers and BLS's agent/broker split side by side.

□ Days 1–30: runway priced; door chosen; management or sales applications started.

□ Days 31–60: coursework converted; interviews at firms that pay salaries.

□ Days 61–90: in a paid seat or final rounds — buildings or quota, both with a base.

□ Day 90: your real-estate knowledge is earning monthly instead of waiting on a closing.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ SALARY FIRST. LISTINGS LATER. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.